UPSC CIVIL SERVICES MAINS | ANTHROPOLOGY OPTIONAL | PAPER I

Topic 8 — Part A
Fieldwork Tradition in Anthropology

Exact syllabus wording covered: "Research methods in anthropology: (a) Fieldwork tradition in anthropology."

THE OPENING STORY

In 1914 a young Polish scholar, Bronisław Malinowski, was in Australia when the First World War broke out. As a subject of Austria-Hungary he was technically an enemy alien. Instead of interning him, the Australian authorities let him go on with his research — so he spent most of 1915 to 1918 on the Trobriand Islands, pitched his tent among the villagers, learnt their language and watched daily life for months on end. The book that came out of it, *Argonauts of the Western Pacific* (1922), opens by asking the reader to imagine being set down alone on a tropical beach as the boat that brought you sails away. **A wartime accident became the founding method of a discipline.**

What this topic is really about. Anthropology is the only social science defined by a **method**: long-term, first-hand fieldwork in which the researcher lives with the people studied. This topic traces how that method was born — from armchair scholars reading travellers' reports, through survey expeditions, to Malinowski's intensive participant observation — and how it has been questioned and remade since: the colonial critique, the reflexive turn, native and feminist anthropology, multi-sited, digital and multispecies ethnography, and the ethics that now govern it all.

Study window	Opens 12 Nov 2026 — **1.5 days** (two sessions), per your Subject Coverage row
Estimated study time	3 hr first pass, including one written 15-mark answer
Revision time	18 min full note • 6 min one-page sheet (Section 15)
Study as	Three units — **the history** (five phases), **the characteristics** of fieldwork, and **today's fieldwork** (critiques, new forms, challenges, ethics). Learn Fig. 1 and Fig. 2 cold.
Note status	Draft 1 — for your review. Not final until you sign it off.
Boundary	The distinction between technique, method and methodology is **8-B**. Tools — observation, interview, genealogy, case study — are **8-C**. Analysis and writing-up are **8-D**. The reflexive critique as theory is **6-J**.

Candid verdict — the single most-asked theme in Topic 8, and still live. Twelve stems between 1998 and 2026: **1998, 1999, 2008, 2011, 2014, 2016, 2017, 2018, 2020, 2024, 2025 and 2026** — and eight more from 1981 to 1989. The last three papers each carried one (contemporary challenges 2024, multi-sited and critical ethnography 2025, fieldwork ethics 2026). Your tracker shows PYQ Count 16 — a figure for all of Topic 8; this sub-topic's own count is **12**, and Mains Value **High** stands. The stems have moved from "trace the history" to "what is fieldwork *now*" — prepare both halves.

2 SCOPE MAP

What is included

- **What fieldwork and ethnography are** — definitions; ethnography as process and product (2018).

- **The history in five phases** — armchair, expedition, Malinowskian, classical and Indian, reflexive and contemporary (1998, 2011, 2014, 2016).
- **Malinowski's method** — the three principles and three kinds of data.
- **Characteristics of anthropological fieldwork** (2017) and its contribution to theory (1999).
- **The critiques** — the diary, Mead–Freeman, the colonial encounter, *Writing Culture*.
- **New forms** — native, feminist, "studying up", multi-sited, multispecies, critical, experiential, digital (2020, 2025).
- **Contemporary challenges** (2024) and **ethics** (2026).
- **The Indian fieldwork tradition** — S. C. Roy to the village studies.

What is excluded, and where it belongs

Material	Belongs to	Why it is kept out
Technique vs method vs methodology; positivism; phenomenology; mixed methods	8-B	The logic of inquiry — a different revision logic
Participant observation as a tool, its types and limits; interview; genealogy; case study	8-C	Named here as part of the tradition only
Sampling; analysis; presentation of data	8-D	After fieldwork
Crisis of representation as theory	6-J, done	Used here for its effect on fieldwork
Colonial administrators and Indian anthropologists in full	Paper II, 4	One paragraph here (5.6)

How it connects outward

- **6-C, 6-B** — Malinowski's functionalism and Boas's particularism came out of their fieldwork; theory and method grew together (the 1999 question).
- **6-J** — the reflexive turn rewrote how fieldwork is reported; the 2020 question on changing presentation of data.
- **8-B, 8-C** — participant observation is both the core of the tradition and a technique; the 2008 stem joined the two.
- **Paper II** — village studies, Elwin, Haimendorf and S. C. Roy; tribal research ethics.

3 PYQ DEMAND AUDIT

Mains

1995–2021 wording and marks from your compilation (Vishnu IAS, Unit 8); Edukemy for 1981–89 and cross-checks; 2024–2026 from the published papers. Marks not recorded for 1998, 1999 and 2008.

Year	Question (as recorded)	Demand	Marks
2026	Ethics in anthropological fieldwork (note).	Principles, cases, India	10
2025	Multispecies, Multi-sited and Critical Ethnography (note).	Three new forms	10
2024	Discuss the contemporary challenges in fieldwork method in anthropological research.	Challenges + responses	15
2020	Experiential ethnography (note).	Rosaldo, Stoller, Jackson	10
2018	Define ethnography and present a brief history of ethnography studies.	Definition + phases	20
2017	Elucidate the basic characteristics of anthropological fieldwork methods.	Characteristics	15
2016	Describe the evolution of fieldwork tradition in Anthropology.	Phases	15
2014	Field work tradition in Anthropology (note).	Phases, compressed	10
2011	Field work tradition in Anthropology (note).	Phases, compressed	15
2008	Discuss the importance of field work in anthropology and describe various tools of data collection.	Importance (+ tools, 8-C)	—

Year	Question (as recorded)	Demand	Marks
1999	Discuss the contributions of field work in the development of anthropological concepts and theories.	Fieldwork → theory	—
1998	Trace the genesis and development of fieldwork in anthropological research. Assess its importance.	Phases + importance	—

Before 1995 (not counted): 1981 place and importance of fieldwork; 1983 fieldwork and theory; 1984 nature of fieldwork and its role in theory; 1985 and 1987 notes on fieldwork traditions; 1986 the informant; 1988 different fieldwork traditions; 1989 balancing theory and field realities.

Prelims

Not applicable. The optional is a Mains paper; GS Prelims has not tested this content.

What UPSC is actually testing

Demand	Times	What is really being tested	Your reading
History / evolution of the tradition	6 — 1998, 2011, 2014, 2016, 2018 (+1980s)	Phases with names, dates and the turning points	5.2–5.4 + Fig. 1. Master Answer 1
Characteristics and importance	3 — 1999, 2008, 2017	What makes fieldwork anthropological, and what it gave theory	5.5 + Fig. 2. Master Answer 2
Fieldwork today	4 — 2020, 2024, 2025, 2026	New forms, challenges, ethics	5.7–5.9. Master Answers 3–4

Trend reading

- **History was the staple until 2018; the present took over from 2020.** Four of the last five stems are about fieldwork now.
- **Notes dominate the recent ones.** 2020, 2025 and 2026 were 10-mark notes. Prepare tight 150-word notes on multi-sited, multispecies, critical, experiential, digital ethnography and ethics.
- **A 15–20-marker is due on history or challenges.** The last full history question was 2018.
- **Mains Value: High.** Twelve askings since 1998; three in the last three papers.

4 BIG-PICTURE CONCEPTUAL MAP

MOVE 1 — From the armchair to the field. Nineteenth-century scholars compiled reports from travellers, missionaries and officials. Expeditions (Torres Strait 1898) and Boas's years with the Inuit and Kwakiutl moved scholars into the field.

MOVE 2 — Malinowski makes it a method. Long residence, the local language, participant observation and three kinds of data — to grasp "the native's point of view". *Fig. 2*

MOVE 3 — The classical age and its spread. Radcliffe-Brown, Evans-Pritchard, Firth, Mead; in India, S. C. Roy, Elwin, Haimendorf and the village studies of the 1950s.

MOVE 4 — The method questioned. The Malinowski diary (1967), the colonial critique (Asad 1973), Mead–Freeman (1983), *Writing Culture* (1986): objectivity, power and authorship under scrutiny.

MOVE 5 — The method remade. Reflexive, collaborative and ethical fieldwork; native, feminist, "studying up", multi-sited, digital, multispecies and critical ethnography. *Fig. 1*

That chain is the shape of any history answer: **armchair → expedition → Malinowski → classical and Indian → critique → remade.**

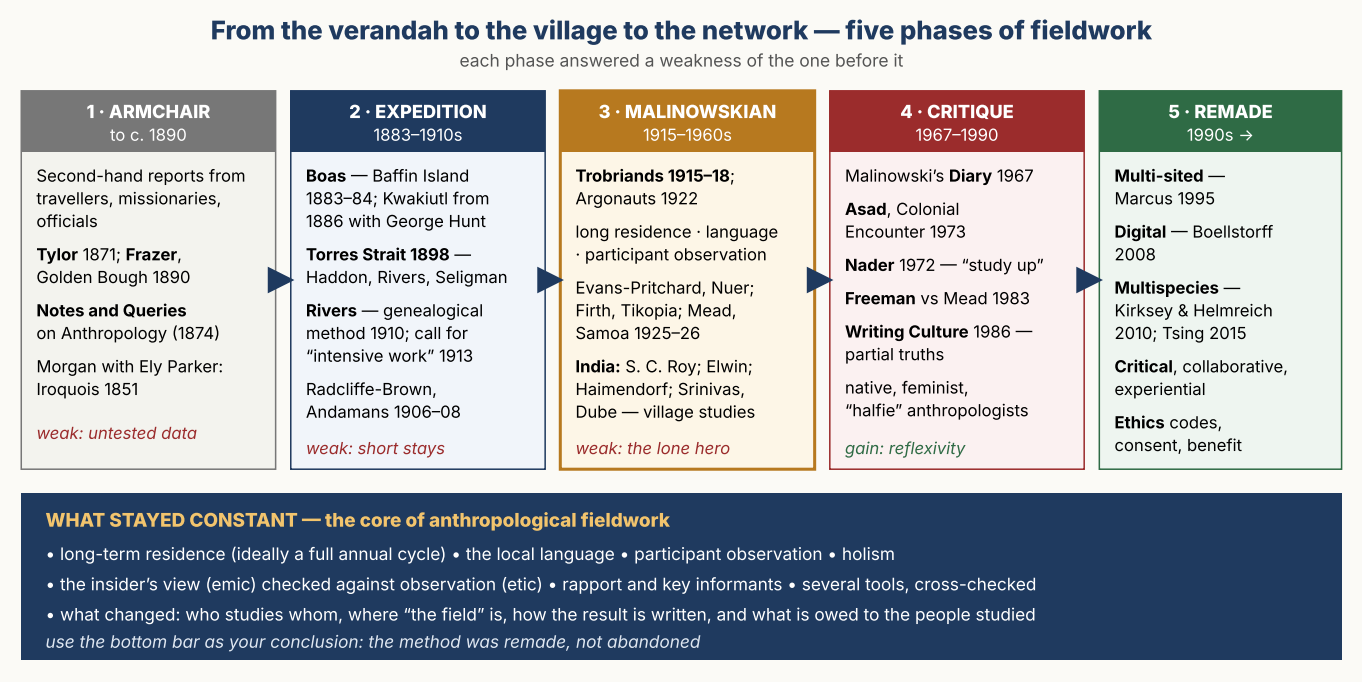


Fig. 1 — the hero diagram. Five phases left to right, each with its names, dates and the weakness the next phase answered; the bar beneath holds what never changed. This is the 2011, 2014, 2016 and 2018 answer on one page.

5 CORE NOTES

5.1 What fieldwork and ethnography are

STORY HOOK

*"Ethnography" means both what you **do** and what you **write**: the months in the village, and the book that comes out of them. Argonauts is an ethnography in both senses.*

Why it helps: it gives you the two-part definition the 2018 question wants.

- **Fieldwork:** first-hand, usually long-term research among a living community, in which the anthropologist collects data by living with the people, learning their language and taking part in their daily life.
- **Ethnography:** (1) the **process** — the fieldwork itself, centred on participant observation; and (2) the **product** — the written, descriptive account of a people's way of life that results. Literally "writing about a people" (Greek *ethnos* + *graphein*).
- **Ethnology:** the comparative and theoretical analysis of ethnographic material across cultures. Ethnography describes; ethnology compares.
- **Why it defines anthropology:** sociology may survey, economics may model; anthropology's claim rests on being there, for long enough to see how things actually work.

5.2 Phase 1 — the armchair (to c. 1890)

STORY HOOK

*As the story goes, when William James asked Sir James Frazer whether he had ever met any of the "savages" he wrote about, Frazer replied: **"God forbid!"** Whether or not he said it, it captures an age when anthropology was done in libraries.*

Why it helps: a one-line picture of the armchair era — mark it as an anecdote.

- **How it worked:** scholars in Europe and America compiled and compared reports from travellers, missionaries, traders and colonial officials.
- **Who:** E. B. Tylor, *Primitive Culture* (1871); James Frazer, *The Golden Bough* (1890); comparative evolutionists generally (6-A).

- **Notes and Queries on Anthropology** (British Association, 1874): a handbook of questions for amateurs in the field — the first attempt to standardise collection.
- **An exception:** Lewis Henry Morgan worked directly with the Seneca Iroquois, helped by the Seneca scholar Ely Parker — *League of the Iroquois* (1851).
- **Weakness:** data were second-hand, uneven and shaped by the observers' prejudices; theory ran far ahead of evidence.

5.3 Phase 2 — expeditions and the first fieldworkers (1883–1910s)

> **STORY HOOK**
> *Franz Boas trained as a physicist — his doctorate was on the colour of seawater. In 1883 he sailed to Baffin Island to study geography, spent the winter with the Inuit, and came back an anthropologist.*
> Why it helps: Boas's turn from physics to people is the American beginning of fieldwork.

- **Franz Boas** — Baffin Island (1883–84); the Kwakiutl of British Columbia from 1886, working closely with George Hunt, a Kwakiutl-Tlingit collaborator who recorded texts. Emphasis on native-language texts, detailed description and "salvage ethnography" of fast-changing cultures.
- **The Cambridge Torres Strait Expedition (1898)** — A. C. Haddon with W. H. R. Rivers, C. G. Seligman, C. S. Myers, William McDougall and Sidney Ray: a team survey of psychology, physical anthropology, language and custom.
- **W. H. R. Rivers** — developed the **genealogical method** (1900; fully stated 1910) and argued for "intensive work" — a single worker living a year or more in a small community (1913). *8-C has the method.*
- **Radcliffe-Brown** — the Andaman Islands (1906–08), published 1922.
- **Weakness:** stays were short, interpreters were used, and the observer remained outside daily life.

5.4 Phase 3 — Malinowski and the classical age (1915–1960s)

> **STORY HOOK**
> *When Malinowski's private field diary was published in 1967, readers met a lonely, irritable man who wrote harshly about the people he studied — the opposite of the patient participant observer of Argonauts.*
> Why it helps: you will use the diary twice — here as the hero's secret, in 5.7 as the start of the critique.

Malinowski's method (Introduction to *Argonauts*, 1922)

Three principles	What they mean
Scientific aims	Know the values and criteria of modern ethnography — go with theoretical problems in mind
Good conditions of work	Live among the people, away from other Europeans; camp in the village
Special methods	Collect, handle and fix the evidence systematically

Three kinds of data	How collected
The skeleton — the "tribal constitution"	Statistical documentation of concrete evidence: genealogies, maps, censuses, synoptic charts
The flesh — the "imponderabilia of actual life"	Close observation of everyday behaviour, recorded in an ethnographic diary
The spirit — native views and opinions	A *corpus inscriptionum* of narratives, sayings, spells and typical utterances

The aim: to grasp the native's point of view, his relation to life, and his vision of his world. MEMORISE — paraphrase closely.

The classical age

- **Evans-Pritchard** — the Azande (1937) and the Nuer (1940); **Raymond Firth** — Tikopia (1936); **Meyer Fortes** — the Tallensi; **Margaret Mead** — Samoa (1925–26; *Coming of Age in Samoa*, 1928); **Ruth Benedict**, culture and personality.

- The classical monograph: one people, one place, the "ethnographic present", a holistic account organised by theory (functionalism, structural-functionalism).

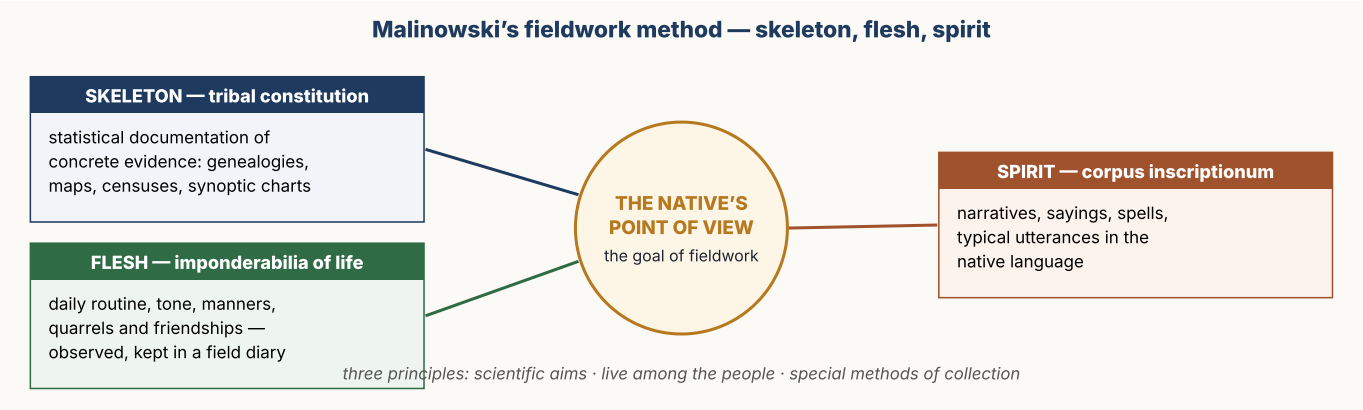


Fig. 2 — Malinowski's three kinds of data converge on one goal. Draw this for any question on characteristics, importance or Malinowski.

5.5 The characteristics of anthropological fieldwork — the 2017 question

#	Characteristic	What it means and why
1	Long-term residence	Usually twelve months or more, to see a full annual cycle of work, ritual and conflict
2	Participant observation	Taking part while watching; the anchor technique
3	The local language	Removes the interpreter; opens talk, humour and nuance
4	Holism	Economy, kinship, politics and religion studied as connected parts
5	Emic and etic together	The insider's categories checked against what is observed
6	Rapport and key informants	Trust built over time; informants as teachers
7	Multiple tools, triangulated	Observation, interview, genealogy, case study, census — cross-checked (8-C)
8	Inductive and qualitative	Questions refined in the field; depth before breadth
9	Small scale, intensive	A village, a neighbourhood, a network — studied closely
10	Reflexivity and ethics	Awareness of one's own position; consent, confidentiality, "do no harm"

What fieldwork gave theory — the 1999 question

- **Functionalism** came from the Trobriands: Malinowski saw the Kula and magic working together in real life (6-C).
- **Segmentary lineage theory** came from Evans-Pritchard's Nuer — order without a state (4-A).
- **Historical particularism** came from Boas's close study of particular histories (6-B).
- **Dominant caste and Sanskritisation** came from Srinivas's Coorg and Rampura fieldwork.
- **Culture and personality** came from Mead's and Benedict's field material (6-E).
- **Fieldwork also unmakes theory:** Leach's Kachin fieldwork showed political systems oscillating, not in equilibrium (1954).

5.6 The Indian fieldwork tradition

STORY HOOK

In 1951–52 a team led by S. C. Dube lived in Shamirpet, a village near Hyderabad, and wrote Indian Village (1955) — one of the first full-length studies of a whole Indian village by an Indian anthropologist.

Why it helps: an Indian field site, and the start of the village-studies era.

- **Colonial ethnography** — H. H. Risley's census ethnography (1901); Edgar Thurston, *Castes and Tribes of Southern India* (1909): survey, measurement and classification for administration.

- **S. C. Roy** — the "father of Indian ethnography": *The Mundas and Their Country* (1912), *The Oraons of Chota Nagpur* (1915), from long residence in Ranchi.
- **Verrier Elwin** — lived among the Baiga and Gond for decades; *The Baiga* (1939).
- **Christoph von Fürer-Haimendorf** — Chenchus, Reddis, the Raj Gonds of Adilabad, the Apatanis; pressed for tribal welfare in Hyderabad State.
- **Village studies (1950s)** — M. N. Srinivas (Rampura, from 1948; *The Remembered Village*, 1976); S. C. Dube (Shamirpet, 1955); McKim Marriott (ed.), *Village India* (1955); D. N. Majumdar.
- **Anthropological Survey of India** (1945) — and K. S. Singh's **People of India** project (1985–92), a nationwide survey of communities.

5.7 The critiques — the method questioned

STORY HOOK

Margaret Mead was twenty-three when she went to Samoa and described a relaxed, low-stress adolescence. In 1983, after her death, Derek Freeman argued that she had been misled — two young Samoan women, he claimed, had been joking with her.

Why it helps: the most famous fight over whether fieldwork can be trusted.

- **The diary (1967)** — the gap between the private Malinowski and the public method: objectivity was partly a literary pose.
- **The colonial encounter** — Talal Asad (ed.), *Anthropology and the Colonial Encounter* (1973): fieldwork depended on colonial power, and its categories served it.
- **Mead–Freeman (1983)** — one island, two pictures; the dangers of short fieldwork, a single theory and a single informant base.
- **"Studying up"** — Laura Nader (1972): anthropologists studied the powerless; they should study the powerful too — corporations, bureaucracies, elites.
- **The crisis of representation** — *Writing Culture* (1986): ethnographic truths are partial; the field account is a text with an author (6-J).
- **Who studies whom** — native or indigenous anthropology; feminist fieldwork; Abu-Lughod's "halfies" (1991) — people of mixed cultural identity who blur insider and outsider.

5.8 New forms of fieldwork — the 2020 and 2025 notes

STORY HOOK

Anna Tsing followed a mushroom — the matsutake — from the forests of Oregon and Finland to the markets of Japan, and wrote an ethnography in which people, fungi and pine trees are all actors: The Mushroom at the End of the World (2015).

Why it helps: one book that is both multispecies and multi-sited — the 2025 note in one image.

Form	What it is	Key names
Multi-sited	Follow the people, the thing, the metaphor, the story, the life or the conflict across places linked in a world system	George Marcus 1995 (*Annual Review of Anthropology*)
Multispecies	Animals, plants, microbes and fungi treated as participants in social life, not backdrop	Kirksey & Helmreich 2010 (*Cultural Anthropology*); Tsing 2015; Haraway
Critical	Ethnography with an explicit commitment to expose and change injustice and power	Jim Thomas 1993; D. Soyini Madison 2005
Experiential	The ethnographer's own bodily and emotional experience as a source of knowledge	Rosaldo 1989; Stoller, *The Taste of Ethnographic Things* 1989; Michael Jackson
Digital / virtual	Fieldwork in online worlds and through digital media	Boellstorff, *Coming of Age in Second Life* 2008

Form	What it is	Key names
Collaborative / participatory	Communities as co-researchers and co-authors	Lassiter 2005; PRA (Chambers)
Auto-ethnography	The researcher's own life and group as the field	Reed-Danahay 1997

5.9 Contemporary challenges (2024) and ethics (2026)

STORY HOOK

*In 1965 the US Army's **Project Camelot** — a social-science study of insurgency, planned for Chile and elsewhere — was exposed and cancelled. The scandal pushed anthropologists to write their first professional ethics statements.*

Why it helps: the origin story of fieldwork ethics.

Challenges

Challenge	What it involves	Response
Access and gatekeeping	States, firms and communities restrict entry; permits; suspicion	Negotiated access; collaboration
Ethics and consent	Informed consent with non-literate or vulnerable groups; review boards	Oral, ongoing consent; local protocols
Positionality	Gender, caste, nation and class of the researcher shape what is seen	Reflexivity; team fieldwork
Safety	Conflict zones, political risk, harassment	Risk planning; remote methods
The unbounded field	Migration, globalisation, digital life — no single "village"	Multi-sited and digital ethnography
Time and funding	Long fieldwork is expensive; academic pressure for speed	Rapid appraisal; "patchwork ethnography"
Representation and return	Communities read and contest what is written about them	Sharing findings; co-authorship
Data protection	Recordings, images, online traces	Anonymisation; secure storage

Patchwork ethnography (Günel, Varma & Watanabe, 2020): shorter, repeated visits combined with remote work — a response to family duties, precarious jobs and the COVID-19 pandemic.

The ethics of fieldwork

- **Codes** — American Anthropological Association: Statement on Problems of Anthropological Research (1967), Principles of Professional Responsibility (1971), Code of Ethics (1998, 2009), Statement on Ethics (2012); ASA (UK) guidelines.
- **Core principles** — **do no harm**; **informed consent**; **openness** about purpose and funding; **confidentiality and anonymity**; obligations to the people studied above sponsors; sharing results; **benefit-sharing** for knowledge and samples.
- **Cases** — Project Camelot (1965); covert research in Thailand (1970); the Yanomami controversy after Patrick Tierney's *Darkness in El Dorado* (2000); the US Army's Human Terrain System (2007), condemned by the AAA.
- **India** — consent with PVTG and forest communities; respect for sacred knowledge; ICMR's national ethical guidelines (2017) for health research; return of findings in local languages.

6 WHAT TO MEMORISE VERSUS WHAT TO UNDERSTAND

Tier	Content
MEMORISE word for word	Five phases with two names and a date each • *Notes and Queries* 1874 • Torres Strait 1898 (Haddon, Rivers) • Boas 1883 Baffin Island • Malinowski: Trobriands 1915–18, *Argonauts* 1922, three principles, three kinds of data, the "native's point of view" • the diary 1967 • Asad 1973 • Nader 1972 • Freeman 1983 • Marcus 1995 • Kirksey & Helmreich 2010 • the ten characteristics • AAA 1971 • four core ethics principles
UNDERSTAND and reproduce flexibly	Why each phase replaced the last • how fieldwork produced theory • why the critiques mattered • how new forms answer old weaknesses • the challenges–responses table
CONCEPTUAL recall only	Torres Strait team members beyond Haddon and Rivers • George Hunt • Thomas, Madison, Lassiter, Reed-Danahay • patchwork ethnography • Human Terrain System

7 HIGH-ROI FACTUAL ANCHORS

Item	What to remember	Why it matters	Story hook
Frazer, 1890	*The Golden Bough*; armchair	Phase 1	"God forbid!"
***Notes and Queries*, 1874**	Questions for amateurs	Phase 1	—
Boas, 1883	Baffin Island; Kwakiutl 1886	Phase 2, America	Colour of seawater
Torres Strait, 1898	Haddon, Rivers; team survey	Phase 2, Britain	—
Rivers, 1910 / 1913	Genealogical method; "intensive work"	Bridge to Malinowski	—
Malinowski, 1915–18 / 1922	Trobriands; *Argonauts*; three principles, three data	Phase 3	Enemy alien on a beach
Diary, 1967	Private Malinowski exposed	Critique	The hero's secret
Dube, 1955	*Indian Village*, Shamirpet	India	Village near Hyderabad
Asad, 1973	*Anthropology and the Colonial Encounter*	Critique	—
Nader, 1972	"Studying up"	Critique	—
Freeman, 1983	Mead and Samoa	Critique	Joking informants
Marcus, 1995	Multi-sited ethnography	2025 note	—
Kirksey & Helmreich, 2010	Multispecies ethnography	2025 note	Tsing's mushroom
Boellstorff, 2008	Second Life ethnography	Digital	An avatar as field self
Project Camelot, 1965	Ethics scandal → AAA statements	2026 note	The cancelled study

8 TECHNICAL VOCABULARY BANK

Term	Simple meaning	Where to use it	Example sentence
Fieldwork	First-hand research living with a community	Every answer	"Fieldwork is anthropology's signature method."
Ethnography	The process of fieldwork and its written product	2018	"Ethnography is both a practice and a genre."

Term	Simple meaning	Where to use it	Example sentence
Armchair anthropology	Theory from second-hand reports	History	"Frazer's was armchair anthropology at its height."
Salvage ethnography	Recording cultures thought to be disappearing	Boas	"Boas practised salvage ethnography among the Kwakiutl."
Participant observation	Taking part while observing	Characteristics	"Participant observation turns a visitor into a learner."
Imponderabilia	Everyday details only long residence reveals	Malinowski	"The imponderabilia of daily life escape the survey."
Rapport	Trust between researcher and community	Characteristics	"Rapport takes months, not days."
Key informant	A local expert who teaches the fieldworker	Characteristics	"Key informants are teachers, not data points."
Reflexivity	Examining one's own influence and position	Critique; ethics	"Reflexivity answers the problem of the invisible observer."
Studying up	Researching the powerful	Critique	"Nader asked anthropologists to study up."
Multi-sited ethnography	Fieldwork that follows connections across places	2025	"Multi-sited ethnography follows the migrant, not the village."
Multispecies ethnography	Non-humans as participants in social life	2025	"Multispecies ethnography treats the mushroom as an actor."
Critical ethnography	Ethnography committed to exposing injustice	2025	"Critical ethnography is fieldwork with a political purpose."
Informed consent	Agreement given with full understanding	2026	"Consent with non-literate groups must be oral and ongoing."

9 ANSWER EXPRESSION TOOLKIT

Definitions to reproduce

- **Fieldwork:** first-hand, long-term research among a living community, in which the anthropologist collects data by residing with the people, learning their language and taking part in their daily life.
- **Ethnography:** both the process of fieldwork centred on participant observation and the written, descriptive account of a people's way of life that results.
- **Fieldwork tradition:** the historically developed set of norms — residence, language, participant observation, holism, reflexivity and ethics — that governs how anthropologists gather knowledge in the field.

Exam-ready opening hooks

- (History) "A wartime accident made a method: interned in spirit but not in body, Malinowski spent 1915–18 among the Trobrianders, and anthropology was never again done from the armchair."
- (Characteristics) "Fieldwork is to anthropology what the laboratory is to chemistry — the place where its knowledge is made."
- (Challenges) "The field is no longer a village reached by boat: it is a migrant network, a city, a website — and the people studied can now read, and answer, what is written about them."
- (Ethics) "Project Camelot (1965) taught anthropologists that who pays for fieldwork, and why, is an ethical question."

Analytical and transition lines

- "Each phase answered the weakness of the one before: the armchair lacked data, the expedition lacked depth, the lone fieldworker lacked reflexivity."
- "Fieldwork did not only test theory; it produced it — functionalism from the Trobriands, segmentary lineage from the Nuer."

- "The critiques did not abolish fieldwork; they changed who does it, where, and with what obligations."

Conclusions

- "The method was remade, not abandoned: long residence, language and participant observation endure, now joined by reflexivity, collaboration and ethics."
- "From the armchair to the avatar, the constant is the same: knowledge earned by being there."

India linkages

- Risley 1901 and Thurston 1909 • S. C. Roy 1912/1915 • Elwin 1939 • Haimendorf (Raj Gonds, Chenchus, Apatanis) • Srinivas, Rampura • Dube, Shamirpet 1955 • Marriott 1955 • AnSI 1945; People of India 1985–92 • ICMR 2017.

10 DIAGRAM BANK

Figure	Verdict	Use it for	How to reproduce in about 30 seconds
Fig. 1 — five phases	HIGHEST ROI — draw it	1998, 2011, 2014, 2016, 2018	Five boxes left to right with two names each and the weakness beneath; a bar of constants underneath
Fig. 2 — skeleton, flesh, spirit	Draw for Malinowski	2017, 1999, 2008	A central circle ("native's point of view") fed by three labelled boxes

11 COMPARISONS AND DEBATES

11.1 Armchair against field anthropology

Basis	Armchair	Field
Data	Second-hand reports	First-hand observation
Scope	World-wide comparison	One community in depth
Theory	Evolutionary stages	Function, structure, meaning
Weakness	Unreliable, out of context	Hard to generalise

11.2 Boas against Malinowski

Basis	Boas	Malinowski
Field	Inuit, Kwakiutl — repeated visits	Trobriands — continuous residence
Data	Native texts, collaborators (George Hunt)	Participant observation, diary, charts
Aim	History of particular cultures	How institutions work now
Legacy	American cultural anthropology	British social anthropology

11.3 Classical against contemporary fieldwork

Basis	Classical	Contemporary
Field	A bounded village	Networks, sites, screens, species
Researcher	Lone Western outsider	Native, team, collaborator
Authority	"I was there"	Reflexive, dialogic
Obligation	To science	To the people studied first

12 MASTER QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

MASTER ANSWER 1 (20 marks). "Define ethnography and present a brief history of ethnography studies." (2018) — also serves 2016, 2014, 2011, 1998.

Ethnography is both a **process** — long-term fieldwork centred on participant observation — and a **product**: the written account of a people's way of life. It is anthropology's signature, and its history is the history of how the discipline learnt to know.

The armchair (to c. 1890). Tylor and Frazer built theory from travellers', missionaries' and officials' reports; the British Association's *Notes and Queries on Anthropology* (1874) tried to standardise them. Morgan's work with Ely Parker on the Iroquois (1851) was an early exception. The data were second-hand and uneven.

Expeditions (1883–1910s). Boas wintered with the Inuit of Baffin Island (1883–84) and studied the Kwakiutl from 1886, recording native texts with George Hunt. The Torres Strait Expedition (1898) under Haddon brought Rivers, who devised the genealogical method and called for "intensive work" by a single fieldworker.

Malinowski (1915–18). Living among the Trobrianders, he set out the method in *Argonauts* (1922): scientific aims, residence among the people, and systematic collection of three kinds of data — the "skeleton" of institutions, the "imponderabilia" of daily life, and native statements — to grasp the native's point of view. Evans-Pritchard, Firth and Mead followed; in India, S. C. Roy, Elwin, Haimendorf and, in the 1950s, the village studies of Srinivas and Dube.

Critique (1967–1990). Malinowski's diary (1967) punctured the myth of the detached observer; Asad (1973) tied fieldwork to colonial power; Freeman (1983) challenged Mead's Samoa; Nader (1972) urged "studying up"; *Writing Culture* (1986) showed ethnographic truths to be partial.

Remade (1990s on). Multi-sited (Marcus 1995), digital (Boellstorff 2008), multispecies (Kirksey and Helmreich 2010), critical and collaborative ethnography, under formal ethics codes. *[Draw Fig. 1.]*

Long residence, language and participant observation endure; what has changed is who studies whom, where the field is, and what is owed to the people studied.

About 360 words. For a 10- or 15-mark note, keep one line per phase and the closing sentence.

MASTER ANSWER 2 (15 marks). "Elucidate the basic characteristics of anthropological fieldwork methods." (2017)

Fieldwork is to anthropology what the laboratory is to chemistry. Since Malinowski's Trobriand research (1915–18) it has had a recognisable set of characteristics.

(1) **Long-term residence**, ideally a full annual cycle, so that seasonal work, ritual and conflict can be seen. (2) **Participant observation** — taking part while watching, which reveals what Malinowski called the "imponderabilia of actual life". (3) **The local language**, removing interpreters and opening talk, humour and nuance. (4) **Holism** — economy, kinship, politics and religion studied as connected. (5) **Emic and etic together** — the people's own categories checked against observed behaviour. (6) **Rapport and key informants**, built over months. (7) **Multiple tools, triangulated** — observation, interview, genealogy, case study and census, each checking the others. (8) An **inductive, qualitative** approach in which questions are refined in the field. (9) **Small scale and intensity** — a village, a neighbourhood or a network. (10) **Reflexivity and ethics** — awareness of the researcher's position, informed consent and "do no harm".

[Draw Fig. 2.] These features let fieldwork generate theory — functionalism from the Trobriands, segmentary lineage theory from the Nuer, the dominant caste from Rampura.

They have limits: findings are hard to generalise, the observer can change what is observed, and long stays are costly. Contemporary practice adds team, multi-sited and collaborative designs while keeping the core.

About 280 words. Numbering the ten characteristics is what the examiner scans for.

MASTER ANSWER 3 (10 marks, about 150 words). "Multispecies, Multi-sited and Critical Ethnography." (2025)

Multi-sited ethnography, named by George Marcus (1995), follows connections across places — the people, the thing, the metaphor, the conflict — because globalised life no longer fits one village. **Multispecies ethnography** (Kirksey and Helmreich 2010) treats animals, plants, microbes and fungi as participants in social life; Anna Tsing's *Mushroom at the End of the World* (2015) follows the matsutake from Oregon's forests to Japan's markets. **Critical ethnography** (Thomas 1993; Madison 2005) joins fieldwork to an explicit purpose of exposing and challenging injustice and power.

All three answer weaknesses of the classical monograph: its bounded field, its human-only focus and its claim to neutrality. They are criticised for thinner depth at each site, for anthropomorphism, and for blurring research and advocacy.

About 140 words.

MASTER ANSWER 4 (10 marks) — skeleton. "Ethics in anthropological fieldwork." (2026)

- **Hook:** Project Camelot (1965) → AAA statements 1967 and 1971.
- **Principles:** do no harm · informed consent (oral, ongoing) · openness about purpose and funding · confidentiality and anonymity · primary obligation to the people studied · return and benefit-sharing.
- **Cases:** Thailand covert research (1970) · Yanomami controversy (*Darkness in El Dorado*, 2000) · Human Terrain System (2007).
- **India:** PVTG and forest communities; sacred knowledge; ICMR 2017 guidelines.
- **Close:** ethics now defines fieldwork as much as residence and language do.

13 MAINS QUESTION BANK

#	Question	Marks	Tags
1	Fieldwork tradition in anthropology.	10	H R D S
2	Multi-sited ethnography.	10	H S
3	Multispecies ethnography.	10	H S
4	Experiential ethnography.	10	H S
5	Ethics in anthropological fieldwork.	10	H S I
6	Malinowski's contribution to fieldwork.	10	R D S
7	Describe the evolution of the fieldwork tradition in anthropology.	15	H R D S
8	Elucidate the basic characteristics of anthropological fieldwork.	15	H R D
9	Discuss the contemporary challenges in fieldwork method.	15	H R S
10	How has fieldwork contributed to the development of anthropological theory?	15	H S
11	Trace the development of fieldwork in India.	15	I
12	Define ethnography and present a brief history of ethnographic studies.	20	H R D S I

H = asked or near-verbatim • R = high ROI • D = needs a diagram • S = needs a scholar or case • I = needs an India linkage.

14 CLOSED-BOOK RECALL DRILL

Core concepts (5)

- Define fieldwork and ethnography (process and product).
- The five phases with two names and a date each.
- Malinowski's three principles and three kinds of data.

Comparisons (3)

- Armchair vs field.
- Boas vs Malinowski.
- Classical vs contemporary fieldwork.

- Ten characteristics of fieldwork.
- Four core ethics principles.

Factual anchors (5)

- *Notes and Queries* — year and purpose.
- Torres Strait — year, leader, the method it produced.
- Boas's two field sites with years.
- Four critiques with authors and years.
- Five Indian fieldworkers with one work each.

Critical judgement (2)

- Eight contemporary challenges with a response each.
- Three theories that came out of fieldwork.

Diagram reproduction (2)

- Draw Fig. 1 with the constants bar.
- Draw Fig. 2 from memory.

Story recall (1)

- Tell each hook in one line: enemy alien, "God forbid!", seawater, the diary, Shamirpet, Mead and Freeman, the mushroom, Camelot.

15 ONE-PAGE QUICK-REVISION SHEET

THE SPINE

Armchair (Tylor, Frazer, *Notes and Queries* 1874) → **expedition** (Boas 1883; Torres Strait 1898; Rivers' genealogy and "intensive work") → **Malinowski** (Trobriands 1915–18; *Argonauts* 1922; three principles; skeleton, flesh, spirit; native's point of view) → **classical and Indian** (Evans-Pritchard, Firth, Mead; S. C. Roy, Elwin, Haimendorf, Srinivas, Dube) → **critique** (diary 1967, Asad 1973, Nader 1972, Freeman 1983, *Writing Culture* 1986) → **remade** (multi-sited 1995, digital 2008, multispecies 2010, critical, collaborative; ethics).

ESSENTIAL TERMS

fieldwork • ethnography • ethnology • armchair • salvage ethnography • intensive work • participant observation • imponderabilia • corpus inscriptionum • rapport • key informant • holism • reflexivity • studying up • multi-sited • multispecies • critical • experiential • patchwork • informed consent

STORY HOOKS

Malinowski the enemy alien • Frazer's "God forbid!" • Boas and seawater • the diary • Dube in Shamirpet • Mead, Freeman and the joking informants • Tsing's matsutake • Project Camelot

ESSENTIAL SCHOLARS

Morgan 1851 • Tylor 1871 • Frazer 1890 • Boas 1883/86 • Haddon, Rivers 1898 • Rivers 1910/13 • Radcliffe-Brown 1906–08 • Malinowski 1922 • Mead 1928 • Evans-Pritchard 1937/40 • Roy 1912 • Elwin 1939 • Srinivas • Dube 1955 • Nader 1972 • Asad 1973 • Freeman 1983 • Marcus 1995 • Boellstorff 2008 • Kirksey & Helmreich 2010 • Tsing 2015

THE THREE LINES TO HAVE WORD-PERFECT

- 1. Ethnography is both the process of fieldwork and the written account it produces.
- 2. Each phase answered the weakness of the one before: no data, no depth, no reflexivity.
- 3. The method was remade, not abandoned — knowledge earned by being there.

DIAGRAM CUES

Fig. 1 five boxes + constants bar • Fig. 2 skeleton / flesh / spirit → native's point of view.

CONFUSIONS TO AVOID

- Ethnography (describes one people) ≠ ethnology (compares many).
- Rivers gave the genealogical method and "intensive work" — before Malinowski.
- The Freeman critique came in 1983, after Mead's death — present it as a contested debate.
- Frazer's "God forbid!" is an anecdote; call it one.

16 SOURCES AND HONEST CAVEATS

- **PYQs** — your 1995–2021 compilation (Vishnu IAS, Unit 8); Edukemy 2013–2023 lists (adds 1981–89); 2024, 2025 and 2026 papers. The 2008 stem is shared with 8-C; I count it here.
- **Mains Value.** Your tracker's PYQ Count of 16 covers all of Topic 8; this sub-topic's count is 12. High stands.
- **Sources** — Malinowski (1922, 1967); Rivers (1910, 1913); Asad; Nader; Freeman; Clifford & Marcus; Marcus (1995); Kirksey & Helmreich; Tsing; Boellstorff; AAA statements; standard Indian sources.
- **Anecdotes and disputes.** Frazer's "God forbid!" is repeated but not firmly documented; Malinowski's wartime status is simplified (an Austro-Hungarian subject allowed to keep researching); Mead–Freeman remains disputed. *Argonauts* lines are close paraphrase.